

**Regular Meeting
Monday, March 18, 2019
Medford School Committee
Council Chambers**

Present: Ms. DiBenedetto, Ms. Kreatz, Ms. Mustone, Mr. Ruggiero, Mr. Ruseau, Ms. Van der Kloot, Mayor Burke, Superintendent Dr. Edouard-Vincent, Associate Superintendent Diane Caldwell, Assistant Superintendent Kirsteen Patterson, and High School Representative Jasper Su.

Roll Call and Salute the Flag - Meeting called to order at 7:50PM.

Approval of Minutes of March 6, 2019 - Ms. DiBenedetto - Please add a note that a request was made for a health policy report, to be added to the requested reports list. Motion to approve as amended offered by Mr. Ruseau, seconded by Ms. Kreatz, motion passes.

Approval of Bills/Transfer of Funds and Approval of Payrolls - Mr. Ruseau - What is the \$400 for Eastern bus three different times at the Brooks for? Is it PTO activity? Ms. Patterson - No, it is student activities. Mr. Ruseau - Universal screening is under athletic services? Ms. Patterson - That is part of the pool account, so the screening they need for STL. I can get further clarification. Motion to approve offered by Ms. DiBenedetto, seconded by Mr. Ruseau, motion passes.

Motion for suspension of the rules offered by Ms. DiBenedetto, seconded by Mr. Ruseau, suspension is granted.

Report on Upcoming MBTA Road Closures - Terry McCarthy - Mr. McCarthy showed a map of the upcoming Green Line Extension project on the Medford line. This past summer they excavated one side of the current location of the commuter rail line. This coming summer they will excavate the other side. Bridge closures are upcoming. The Broadway Bridge will close this Friday, March 22nd, and it will be closed for a year. There will be a free shuttle service offered by the City of Somerville to avoid the area as a pedestrian. This information is available online and if anyone wants this presentation it can be emailed. Buses will be re-routed. There has been a lot of local outreach so the community is aware of the closures and changes. Mayor Burke - National Grid has agreed to fix a gas leak near there and there will be a lot of activity in one area. We thank you for the communication.

Recommendation to Approve Donation to McGlynn Middle School by Medford Engineering and Survey - Nicholas Tucci - The McGlynn Middle School has been awarded a \$500 donation. It

will be a contest in spring of 2019 in which students compete to reflect on The Mustang Way. The donation will be used to incentivize participation in the contest. Thank you to Mr. Veniziano and Ms. Hong Liu for helping us get this donation. Motion to approve offered by Mr. Ruggiero, seconded by Ms. Mustone.

Roll call vote: 7 Affirmative, 0 Negative, motion passes.

Recommendation to Approve Scholarship for Curtis Tufts Student - Kirsteen Patterson - This scholarship would be to begin with the Class of 2019 for a student with promise entering a trade school, as an ongoing scholarship. Motion to approve offered by Ms. Van der Kloot, seconded by Ms. DiBenedetto. Ms. Van der Kloot - Can we send a thank you letter for the scholarship? Mayor Burke - Yes, and one for the donation to the McGlynn Middle School as well.

Roll call vote: 7 Affirmative, 0 Negative, motion passes.

Recommendation to Approve Commencement Exercises at Tufts University - Paul D'Alleva - Motion to approve offered by Ms. DiBenedetto, seconded by Ms. Kreatz.

Roll call vote: 7 Affirmative, 0 Negative, motion passes.

Ms. Van der Kloot - Now that we are through the snow season, can we state the last day of school? Dr. Edouard-Vincent - It should be June 13th.

Recommendation to Approve 2019-2020 School Calendar - Diane Caldwell - You have a draft calendar in your packets. Ms. DiBenedetto - Can you post this calendar and the last day of school on the website? Mr. Ruggiero - Can we please include a lottery date for middle school selection? Mayor Burke - This is broad rather than specific. Motion to approve offered by Ms. DiBenedetto, seconded by Mr. Ruseau, motion passes.

Motion to revert to regular business offered by Ms. DiBenedetto, seconded by Ms. Van der Kloot, motion passes.

Report of Committees - Special Education Sub Committee, February 5, 2019 - Ms. DiBenedetto - The member listed all attendees to the meeting, a diverse group of stakeholders. Motion to accept the report and place on file offered by Mr. Ruseau, seconded by Ms. Van der Kloot, motion passes.

Report of the Superintendent - Dr. Edouard-Vincent - There was a police incident at the Roberts School and students, parents, and teachers in the After School program had to shelter-in-place. I apologize for miscommunication surrounding that event.

Medford High School and Medford Vocational/Technical High School held a celebration of Black History Month. Thank you to all involved.

Thank you to the City-wide PTO for a wonderful event hosting the Harlem Wizards. They worked very hard and congratulations on selling 800 tickets.

Last week, March 14th, was Pi Day. I celebrated Pi Day at the McGlynn Middle School. It was a wonderful learning event.

An update on Tristen Howard: last Friday he traveled to New York City to compete in the New Balance Nationals. He ran very fast but unfortunately did not move on to the finals. We congratulate him and he is only a junior so we have another year to see what wonderful things he will do.

This Saturday I attended the Japanese Language School graduation. I thank the Consul General and Principal for inviting me and Mayor Burke to the graduation. They have been partnered with Medford High School for 45 years, a long standing relationship.

On Wednesday, March 20th in Bistro 489, from 6-9 PM, the Medford Public Schools and Winchester Public Schools Offices of Special Education are holding their Annual Transition Fair designed for students 14 years of age and older with disabilities, to help plan for life after high school. The exhibitors will include information regarding support for independent living skills, vocational training, adapted educational programs, recreational opportunities and supported housing.

Wednesday, March 20th is an early release day. The McGlynn Middle School is hosting a free ice skating event at LoConte for McGlynn Middle School students. At MHS, Priscilla's Pantry will offer rice and beans from 12-12:30pm, in Cafe 3, for any student who might be interested.

Mr. Ruseau - Thank you. Can you provide a report on what happened at the Roberts and what we can do for the future, in executive session if necessary? I am not clear what our procedures are.

Report on 2018 Mathematics MCAS Strategic Analysis and Curriculum Initiatives - Faiza Khan - Students took the new test in grades 3 through 8 last year, and the legacy test for grade 10. This year grade 10 will take the new format test, so they will all take the new version together. The

report includes results of the tests for our students. On page 5 you see the cusp scores, that shows how close our students are to meeting expectations. These data support the use of the new math curriculum that was adopted when last year's 3rd graders were in kindergarten. You can see the steps we have taken to analyze the data and see where our students need to improve. Our student growth percentile has stayed within the statewide mean. We have taken many steps to improve scores, in-district and out-of-district. Mr. Ruseau - Is there significance to the difference from one percentage point to the next? What is important about it? Ms. Khan - There are many factors that go into this. When you really look into it, it could have been demographics, a certain set of students, they had a bad nights sleep, maybe we failed to identify a particular problem. Mr. Ruseau - Do teachers use these scores to determine grades? Ms. Khan - No, teachers use unit tests for grades. We analyze the data with math coaches and the coaches go back to the teachers. Mr. Ruseau - I am concerned we spend too much time testing and not enough time teaching. Motion that we provide a report to the committee of all tests including practice tests, including frequency and duration of the tests, but not tests that are used for grades. Ms. DiBenedetto - I like seeing this data. Is it broken down by subgroups? For the future, please break these reports down by subgroups. Ms. Van der Kloot - In grade 4 and 5 there seems to be struggle with fractions. Some of your action items include remedial help. Can it be worked into classrooms? Ms. Khan - Yes, they are already doing that. They are also doing professional development with teachers. Ms. Van der Kloot - You mention you would like to adopt an inquiry-based mathematics program, when would you like to do this? Is that for this coming year? Ms. Khan - There are some programs out there. I have asked some teachers to pilot it and they have for a couple of years now. Illustrative Math is the program. I invite everybody to give it a try if you are interested. Big Ideas Book, Ambitions Program. Ms. Van der Kloot - Will you bring that to us during budget time? Dr. Edouard-Vincent - Yes. Ms. Van der Kloot - I want to say thank you for sharing the concept with me about productive struggle. Mr. Ruggiero - On page 5, there is a significant drop from grade 3 to grade 4. Why is that? Ms. Khan - These students were using Everyday Math. The students were tested on 2017 frameworks, not 2011, which is what the curriculum is from. Mr. Ruseau - On page 9, I was surprised to see that kindergarten to 5th graders are offered 70 minutes of continuous math instruction. Ms. Khan - Sometimes there are two different breaks during a math block. We are giving our students 65 or 60 minutes of math. We do 10 minutes, we teach something else, we come back to it. Sometimes it is mixed with snack. Math blocks can be interrupted, but as long as the flow is not interrupted, that is the goal. It takes away from focus. Divise a mathematics block that keeps students learning and focused at the center of that learning. Maybe I had my high school mathematics hat on. Mr. Ruseau - Thank you.

Motion to request a report with each math topic broken down by school offered by Mr. Ruggiero, seconded by Ms. DiBenedetto, motion passes.

Motion that a report be provided to the Committee by May 6th detailing all tests, including practice tests, give to students K-8 grades, broken out by grade level and school, exempting unit tests teachers give to assess grades, including frequency and planned duration of tests and practice tests offered by Mr. Ruseau, seconded by Ms. Mustone. Motion passes.

Report on 2018 Science MCAS Strategic Analysis and Curriculum Initiatives - Rocco Cieri - Grades 5 and 8 will take the next generation MCAS and the high school will take legacy. The next generation is a computer-based test. Benchmarking will happen for the first time this year. Our data analysis for this year will probably have to change for next year based on new data points we will have. We are adapting to a new testing type while making sure we maintain a certain consistency. Two domains showed discrepancy: life science and earth science. We have to think deeply about how to use that information going forward. Mr. Ruseau - Is there a typo on the cusp scores? Mr. Cieri - They score on 2.8. If we look at the cusp data we can see that if we were to improve one or two questions it would result in significantly improved outcomes. DESE released additional practice questions very late so it was hard to give students an idea about how the test will go. Our new FOSS science curriculum can allow us to collect some additional data that can be used as a tool for us. I congratulate you on choosing the FOSS science curriculum for our students. We got pallets of materials from them and they are almost entirely delivered, it was a huge amount of materials. In addition, we have provided training for the teachers on how to use that first unit. We started with earth science. It is exciting for the kids with very developmentally appropriate materials. The teachers are excited. Next year when we start school, we will start with earth science. Then we will move to physical science and life science in the spring. There will be many living things in the classroom. We are refining some topics at 6 to 12 level. I caution against looking only at the deficits. Concepts change and are new, which can be difficult to follow. If students are one or two questions away, that is test taking strategy. There are also simple writing techniques, repeating the question, stating the evidence. We would want to look into investing in a new curriculum for middle schools. Amplify Science is directly connected to the FOSS curriculum. It does require technology. Tufts has been a great partner with the science department and it has been beneficial from an instructional and student experience standpoint. Mr. Ruggiero - Please explain the table on page 4. Mr. Cieri - We identified the 5 questions with the greatest struggle for students that revealed the most to us as a district. Mr. Ruggiero - Can we have a pdf of all the different items and districts and state scores? It would be nice for me to see more information, broken down by school. Mr. Ruseau - When we get the item number we don't get the question? Mr. Cieri - You can see the question. Ms. DiBenedetto - We do not want to be too worried about cusp scores, we want to know where we are and improve, wherever we are now, so we can take concrete steps to move forward. Ms. Van der Kloot - Will report requests tie you up for hours and hours? Mr. Cieri - We can do it. Ms. Van der Kloot - I do not want us to tie up our professionals and prevent them from doing the work they need to do. I look forward to hearing more about Amplify Science. Will we hear more about it? Mr. Cieri - We will present

you with all the options. I suspect Amplify Science will rise to the top. Ms. Van der Kloot - When will this come out? Mr. Cieri - This June. Motion to accept report and place on file offered by Ms. Van der Kloot, seconded by Ms. Kreatz, motion passes.

Suspension of rules offered by Ms. Van der Kloot at 9:35pm, seconded by Ms. DiBenedetto - Mayor Burke - Condolences read: Dorothy Palladino, Anthony Staffier, and Phyllis Louise McCormack.

Motion to revert to regular schedule offered by Ms. DiBenedetto seconded by Ms. Van der Kloot, motion passes.

Report on 2018 English Language Arts MCAS Strategic Analysis and Curriculum Initiatives - Dr. Nicole Chiesa - There are two different tests now for different grades, the next generation and the legacy. Some students struggle with the technology in the next generation, perhaps not knowing they have to scroll down. DESE has made it clear that any type of writing is possible to appear on the test. They need to be exposed to all different types of writing throughout the year. We deal with issues of stamina when preparing for a test. I followed up with DESE on why grade 3 is only listed as reading, when all other grades are listed as ELA. DESE agreed that it was not accurate and they will be changing it. The legacy test involved a lot of pulling from prior knowledge of novels, but the next generation is a different format and this year the high school students will be moving to that. The cusp scores would have made a major difference if the students had scored slightly better. We are on par for the state for the most part in ELA. The student growth percentile report shows that we are growing as a district year by year. Every teacher knows individuals who are doing well, who is on the cusp, and who is struggling. We also look at schedule changes. We have identified some high needs 6th graders so we can provide more support. At the high school level we work to support ELA literacy piece for students who need more support. We practice to reduce test anxiety and to overcome technological issues. We recently implemented an ELA enrichment academy. We are looking to technology updates to help solve problems. One area we saw was a drag-and-drop question. Ms. Mustone - Do the computer teachers teach the students how to use the technology? Dr. Chiesa - I have worked with Ms. Laden to develop those skills. We do give them blocks of time to make sure they know how to do it. Mr. Ruseau - I do not have a mouse at home. It is a different technology. Dr. Chiesa - It can be frustrating for students. Mr. Ruggiero - How many words per minute can a third grader type? Dr. Chiesa - We had typing dot com, an online platform, set up accounts for students and they can track typing. Some principals incentivize typing. I get concerned about stamina for writing and I get concerned about conventions. Mr. Ruggiero - Are the tests machine graded or human graded? Dr. Chiesa - They are human graded for now. Mr. Ruggiero - What do they grade based on? Dr. Chiesa - They use a standard rubric. Our teachers use it too. All the teachers are very aware that graders can be more stringent on grading and the

information is passed on to students. Ms. DiBenedetto - Thank you. Subgroup information would be helpful. I do not like to see cusp grades. Motion to receive and place on file offered by Ms. DiBenedetto, seconded by Mr. Ruseau, motion passes.

Motion to go into executive session offered by Ms. Van der Kloot, seconded by Ms. DiBenedetto.

Roll call vote: 7 affirmative 0 negative, motion passes. Entered executive session at 10:18pm.

Executive session began at 10:25pm, all members were present.

Executive session ended at 10:50pm.